

Overcoming obstacles

The Koilwar Bridge over the River Sone near Arrah, Bihar, stands out because of the challenges the river threw up. A 3–5 km narrow stream for most of the year with a bed of fine sand, it would flood and discharge water up to 50,000 cubic metres per second during the rainy season.

The almost 1,440-m-long bridge had three brick wells that had to be sunk to a depth of 9.8 m below water onto a bed of yellow clay to make it sturdy. Governor-General Lord Elgin, while inaugurating it in 1863, said that the “magnificent bridge is exceeded in magnitude by only one bridge in the world,” perhaps an allusion to the Victoria Bridge in Montreal, Canada, which was inaugurated in 1860.



▲ **A combination of stone, brick, iron, and steel**, the 230-m-long and 55-m-wide Ehagaon Viaduct stretches across a valley along the Thul Ghat incline in the Western Ghats.